



NUTRITION DURING PREGNANCY

Why Nutrition Matters in Pregnancy

Good nutrition during pregnancy supports fetal brain development, healthy birth weight, and reduced risk of complications. Nutritional needs increase during pregnancy, and certain nutrients become especially important.

Key Nutrients During Pregnancy

- Folic acid (400–800 mcg daily): Prevents neural tube defects. Start before conception if possible.
- Iron (27 mg daily): Supports increased blood production and prevents anemia.
- Calcium (1,000 mg daily): Builds the baby's bones and teeth.
- Vitamin D (600 IU daily): Works with calcium to support bone development.
- Omega-3 fatty acids (DHA): Supports fetal brain and eye development.
- Iodine: Supports thyroid function and fetal brain development.
- Protein: Necessary for fetal tissue growth and uterine development.

Foods to Emphasize

- Leafy greens, legumes, and fortified cereals (folate, iron)
- Dairy products or fortified alternatives (calcium, vitamin D)
- Lean meats, poultry, fish, eggs, and beans (protein, iron)
- Fatty fish like salmon (DHA omega-3s - limit to 2-3 servings/week)
- Whole grains (fiber, B vitamins)
- Colourful fruits and vegetables (vitamins C, A, antioxidants)

Foods and Substances to Avoid

- Raw or undercooked meat, eggs, and fish
- High-mercury fish (shark, swordfish, king mackerel, tilefish)

- Unpasteurized dairy products and juices
- Alcohol (no safe level is established during pregnancy)
- Excess caffeine (limit to under 200 mg per day)
- Deli meats unless heated until steaming (listeria risk)

Key Takeaway

A balanced, varied diet with appropriate supplementation supports a healthy pregnancy. A prenatal vitamin helps fill nutritional gaps but does not replace a healthy diet.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Nutrition during pregnancy. Office on Women's Health (2021). Staying healthy and safe. March of Dimes. (2020). Eating and nutrition.